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How I Learned to Jump Higher Than LeBron James

“Practice Practice Practice” – Steven Christie

My father taught me that the key to succeeding in this life is knowing that anything is possible with enough practice. If you want to get better at something, work on it as feverishly as you can.

I'd like to thank Joel Smith of “Just Fly Sports Performance” and Daniel Back of “Jump-Science.com” for always offering me their time and expert advice. Their guidance has been a large reason for my continued athletic success. If you are interested in learning more about jumping higher, I'd highly recommend researching them.

I also need to make something clear: I am NOT a physician or a certified trainer; I am just a regular man who learned to jump very high. You should always consult a physician before beginning an exercise program.

Preface:

LeBron James is the the most phenomenal athlete I have ever seen in action. He is probably the most powerful, explosive, intelligent, and coordinated athlete in the world today. After 10 years of training, I can jump just barely higher than LeBron, who has not specifically trained to jump higher. This is a testament to his greatness. His highest filmed jump shows his head reaching 5 inches over the rim (a generous estimate), corresponding to roughly a 45 inch vertical. My best jumps ever, after many years of passionate and daily dedication, have been in the range of 46 to 47 inches.

This is my journey.

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Chapter 1: How It All Started

I am a 5'9" college student and I learned to jump higher than LeBron James. For as long as I can remember, I have wanted to jump high. Through hard work and passionate perseverance, I've accomplished my goal. The process has taught me important things, but not only about jumping. It has also taught me that anybody can achieve great things by developing certain habits, like sticking to a project, and being consistent. Let me tell you my story, so you can learn how I got to this point.

In order to be great at anything, there is a certain level of passion required. In my case I started very early. The first day of my journey was my first day in middle school, when I walked into my first period class as the shortest kid in school. I was nervous and felt uneasy. Our teacher was late, and all the boys in my class began to try to jump and touch the roof of the classroom. Many tried but none succeeded. After working up the courage I decided to give it a go. I knew I was the shortest kid there and no one expected me to touch it so I had nothing to lose. Much to my surprise I ran up, jumped, and touched the roof. I was the only one in my class who was able to do so. I had finally found something that I was actually kind of good at.

I had been told my whole life that there was no way someone as short as I would ever be able to dunk a basketball. I decided that my two main goals were to make the basketball team and to one day be able to dunk. I loved basketball and I was feverishly competitive, but my lack of confidence and short stature had me limited to bench and sideline roles in every sport I tried. I tried out every year, from 6th grade to 9th grade with

no success! Every year I was told, “Come back next year”.

I devoted every spare moment to the task of making the team. I remember training alone every summer. I remember pretending to go to the bathroom during class and doing calf raises in empty rooms. I’ll never forget the embarrassment of showing up every year for try-outs and failing publicly. I remember crying alone in the bathroom after being cut from the 9th grade tryouts. Around that time I finally began to grow to average height and my jumping skills improved. At that time I was about 5’5” and just barely able to touch the rim. My training up until that point had just been basketball drills, calf raises, and dunking on low rim hoops with my friends for about an hour a day roughly 3-5 times a week.

Every year that I embarrassed myself at tryouts, I would dedicate the following months to intense workouts and also to practicing any gimmick I had heard of to jump higher. I was trying to make up for my lack of height. I bought jump program after program, I bought those silly platform-strength shoes and I began reading every jump-related piece of literature I could get my hands on. Through much trial and error, I finally started to find success.

A lot of my progress is documented on YouTube (look up “NDJPro” to find my videos). I began posting videos of myself dunking on 8-foot rims, including the memorable time I first touched the rim. I had been trying for many months without success, and finally, on my 15th birthday, I touched the bottom of the rim on my first attempt. I had been dreaming about that moment since 6th grade, and I yelled my excitement. It was the greatest achievement I could imagine. I immediately called my

best friend Daniel, who had been trying to touch the rim as well with me every day, overwhelmed with joy. I had learned a valuable lesson: the only way to get better at anything in this life is to practice incessantly. Immediately I set my next goal: dunking.

Tenth grade came along and I knew that this was the year I was going to accomplish my two biggest goals: Making the basketball team and landing my first dunk. In a way, I hardly even cared for basketball anymore. Instead, I cared about achieving goals that had been out of reach for too long. I was envious of the taller, more experienced guys who had been playing each of those four years I had been cut. And I was sure that this would finally be my year. I again gave it my all and trained alone all summer. I showed up to tryouts, again, as the shortest person there. But this time I was by far and away the most athletic person on the court. I had achieved this level of athleticism by jumping as much as I could every day! I could jump up and hang on the rim at 5'7", I was significantly faster than anyone on the court, and I wanted it way more than anyone else.

The first roster cut was posted, and my name was still on the list! After the last day of tryouts, the coach approached me in private and told me I was going to make the team. I nearly broke down in tears. I honestly never thought that day would come. The season came and passed and I learned a lot about myself. I learned that while I loved the experience and the bonds I made with the team, basketball wasn't what I was actually passionate about. I was actually passionate about jumping itself, and not because I would be a better basketball player. I was also fascinated by the knowledge that I could improve myself through sheer perseverance and hard work. Succeeding at

jumping told me I could succeed at much more.

I still had my second goal of my 10th grade year to achieve. By the end of basketball season I could get a couple inches above the rim, but I had yet to dunk. I began to experiment with more specific training, in the process discovering what worked for me and what didn't. I grew to 5'9" (my current height) and after months of trying and not even being close, the miracle happened: I dunked.

I remember the day perfectly. I had been training harder than ever and I went to the gym with the friend who I often trained with. He would toss the ball right over the rim, and I would approach at full speed and take off in an attempt to barely push the ball through the rim. Hours passed that day and I had come painfully close nearly a hundred times. Then someone who I was not particularly fond of walked into the gym. He had been telling me for years that I wouldn't be able to dunk, and now that I was getting close he instead would tease me and tell me that a "dunk is still only worth two points". (You know who says that by the way? **People who can't dunk.**) Daniel tossed the ball up one last time and I took off. I floated, and for a second I felt weightless. I was completely alone in the world with the ball and the rim. I pushed the ball through the rim.

I had done it! I yelled in total satisfaction. I felt even more accomplished than I had when I made the basketball team. I had been dreaming of this moment for most of my life. I had dedicated blood, sweat and years to this endeavor. From that moment I was hooked.

My passion only grew and I was eager for more. My next goals were to hit every dunk possible, from two hands, to 360's, to windmills and between the legs. I wanted to

become the greatest dunker I could possibly be. I knew that many people could not understand my dedication to something that seemed a weird passion. But I also knew that in this journey to jumping higher I was achieving something much more important than vertical height. I had discovered the key to achieving any worthwhile goal.

I learned that it is the simple, persevering repetition and constant dedication that wins in the end—not the spectacular or freaky. While I have improved and progressed since that first dunk, the truth is I got to that level of athleticism by essentially dunking on my local 8 foot rim every day for an hour. There is no better jump training than jumping itself and that is especially true for younger athletes. And of course, there is no better training for any endeavor than the endeavor itself. Practice, persevere, stick to it—and you will achieve.

Chapter 2: The Science of Jumping

In order to learn to jump higher, you need to know what it means to jump. The simple fact is the more force you can exert into the ground the higher you can jump. So if it is that simple, why can't everyone dunk or jump high? Why are the strongest people not the highest jumpers?? Why is it that people with super skinny legs can jump through the roof? The answer is because there are many different factors that contribute to a good jump. The three *main* factors in a jump are how much force you can exert into the ground, how quickly you can exert all that force and how efficient your techniques and movements are. It doesn't only matter how strong or fast you are, what matters is how strong you are in the proper position and in the split second it takes to jump.

So the three main trainable characteristics of a jump are max strength, rate of force development and jump technique. Training for the three is extremely complex. Through years and years of practice I have personally figured out the most efficient ways to train them each of them while minimizing the negative effects they often have on each other.

In order, the most important qualities to train are jump technique, rate of force development, and lastly, strength. The reason for this order is that jumping is primarily a learned skill. Learning and mastering the skill will yield the greatest results. The reason I place more emphasis on rate of force development than strength is that most athletes will increase their strength levels automatically while doing exercises focused on increasing their rate of force development. Strength, while incredibly important, is last

because truthfully jumping high does not always require immense levels of strength.

The best high jumpers and dunkers would not usually impress anyone in a powerlifting event.

Chapter 3: The Skill of Jumping

If you had one week to get as good at jumping as you possibly could--if your life depended on jumping higher than you have ever before, what would you do? The correct answer is not to lift weights or to do sprint exercises, the real answer is you would need to jump, jump, jump, and jump some more. To get better at any thing requires that you do that thing as much as you physically can. You need to ingrain that movement pattern into your body and mind. The more jumps you do the more efficiently your body will learn to jump and the more your technique will improve. To put it simply, the best way to jump higher, is to get better at jumping.



Nearly everybody can increase their vertical leap dramatically just by becoming better at the skill of jumping. Without even getting stronger or more explosive you can make major improvement. I have been jumping nearly every day for 10 years and I am still learning and fine-tuning my technique. My best advice is to listen to your body. Study, but do not over analyze your jump. By doing the motion over and over again your body will naturally figure out it's most effective way of jumping. As a beginner it is likely that your technique is not optimal or even pretty. It may be frustrating to watch some of the highest jumpers in the world, study their technique, and for some reason not be able to mimic their style and positions. Even if you are conscious of what proper technique is supposed to look like, as a beginner you will not likely be able to jump your highest using textbook form. That is because elite jumpers have built their bodies (through years of jumping) into jumping machines, able to contort and apply force in an optimal position. The way you naturally currently jump, is the way your body is currently able to jump its highest. As the days, weeks, months, years, and even decades go by your body will start to perform like the jumping machine you have redesigned it into and your technique will resemble that of other elite jumpers. I recommend watching footage of your jumps, trying to pinpoint ways that you think your jump may be improved, and experimenting with new approaches and methods.

Chapter 4: Rate of Force Development

The rate at which you are capable of producing maximum force is one of the most important qualities to train when trying to increase your vertical leap. To explain what this mean I will propose a hypothetical question. *Who do you think can jump higher between two identical twins of the same height and weight? The one who can deadlift 400 pounds in a four second effort or the one who can deadlift 400 pounds in one second?* The answer is almost certainly guy who can lift the weight faster. Being able to exert a lot of force is important, but only if you can do so rapidly. The exercise that requires the highest rate of force development is a max effort sprint. Think about some of the fastest people you knew and grew up with, most likely they were will also pretty decent leapers. Speed is a common characteristic of anyone who can jump high. There is a reason the fastest NFL players and the fastest track athletes have the highest measured vertical leaps. So, how do you train for speed? Firstly, the most explosive exercise you can do is sprint. The best way to ensure elite athleticism is to have built up a long history of maximum effort sprinting.



Take a look at elite sprinters in the track and field world. Every top level 100m sprinter is amazingly built and for the most part their training consists of mainly sprinting! Sprinting alone can earn you an incredibly powerful physique, but sprinting is often neglected as we grow older in our training. There is no other exercise with faster ground contact times and rates of force development. When you perform a heavy squat you are exerting force for roughly 2 to 3 seconds per repetition. When you are jumping your ground contact time is somewhere around .25 to .5 seconds and when you are sprinting your ground contact times can be as little as .1 seconds! Nothing trains you to become stronger in a short amount of time than sprinting does.

There are also exercises known as plyometric exercises that can help you

maximize the rate of force that you develop during a jump. Most likely, as someone who is interested in learning to jump higher, you have come across these exercises a few times. Some examples include box jumps, depth jumps, tuck jumps, and jump rope. Jumping drills can be varied and combined to produce incredible results.



While jumping is technically a “slower” act than sprinting, it is still incredibly fast and explosive. The total force you exert into the ground is significantly greater on a jump than a sprint. One of the most important lessons I've ever learned (and one that I will continue to reiterate) is that if you want to get better at something you need to do that thing as much as possible. I am one of the highest jumpers in the world, and the biggest reason is that there are very few people on earth who have jumped as many times as I have. I recently calculated how many max effort jumps (in the form of dunks and dunk attempts) I have performed during the last 4 years at roughly 150,000!

When I was younger I accidentally stumbled on perhaps the greatest plyometric

exercise there is: Dunking. Even before I could dunk on a regulation rim, I would be dunking on lower rims for hours and hours nearly every day for years. I was doing it simply for fun, but I had zero clue that it was perhaps the greatest thing I could be doing to help me jump higher. This is a picture of me attempting a dunk at fifteen years old.



Dunking is an incredible exercise for two main reason: Each dunk is a max effort jump and each different dunk (360, windmill, between the legs, over people, etc.) has its own unique training effect. The variability of each dunk keeps improvement more consistent and prevents athletes from plateauing as easily. This is why I advise anyone hoping to dunk to begin dunking on a lower rim for about an hour a day, 2-3 days a week. Don't even focus on how much higher you are starting to jump, just try to master as many unique and difficult dunks as possible. Once you have mastered plenty of dunks, raise the rim a couple inches and begin that process all over again. It is absolutely the best way to learn to jump higher and become an amazing dunker. Not only will you transform

your body and athleticism, but another consequence is that your “dunk technique” will be incredible when beginning to dunk on 10 feet. This is a picture of me dunking just a few years later.



Chapter 5: Strength

As I have tried to make clear, jumping and sprinting are maximal effort motions with very little ground contact time that train your body to react explosively, responsively, and with a tremendously high rate of force development. Many people can achieve 40-inch verticals, and in fact, many of the highest jumpers in the world achieved their results simply through sprinting and jumping alone, without weight-training. For most people, though, that is not realistic and a degree of strength training is also necessary.

Becoming stronger is essential when attempting to become more athletic, but you need to be diligent and thoughtful in the pursuit of strength. What's the use of becoming stronger if you become too heavy and slow to use that strength in any athletic way? This is Benedikt Magnusson, one of the strongest men alive.



Benedikt can deadlift over one thousand pounds, but he doesn't jump nearly as high as I do. The reason is because he weighs nearly 400 pounds. More important than absolute strength is the athlete's strength-to-weight ratio. Every good athlete is strong in proportion to the weight of his body. Even excellent athletes who have no experience in the weight room are usually strong in relation to their body weight. Increasing your strength to weight ratio is beneficial in nearly all to athletic pursuits. Besides competing and practicing the sport you play the best way to get stronger is by spending plenty of time in the gym.

The three most important lifts for increasing your strengths are the deadlift, the squat, and the bench/overhead press. Getting proficient at these movements will increase your athleticism. Interestingly though, adding strength is only helpful to a point. Most athletes don't ever reach this point, but once someone is capable of squatting twice their bodyweight achieving full depth (as in getting your butt to your ankles) and deadlifting 2.5-3 times their bodyweight there is not usually a significant use in achieving more strength.

It is also important to note that strength training is risky because of some of the negative physical and neurological adaptations that result from it. After lifting extremely heavily for a long period of time, our bodies become more easily fatigued, heavier, and sometimes significantly slower at producing force. This is because max lifts can have durations of 2-4 seconds per repetition, and that long time frame is not very similar to the quarter-second it takes to jump. These longer durations train our bodies to move

more slowly and the fatigue of lifting heavy weights accumulates and dampens the excitability of our central nervous systems. I have seen many great athletes (myself included a few years ago) decrease their athleticism in a blind pursuit of absolute strength. Strength training is helpful, but up to a certain point it can become less helpful and even detrimental to your pursuit of jumping higher.

I will explain the significance of strength by asking you some questions. Who do you think jumps higher, someone who can squat 400 pounds or someone who can squat 100 pounds (assuming they are the same height and weight)? The answer almost nearly always is the guy who can squat 400 pounds. This is because stronger people are also typically stronger in the split second it takes to jump. But in another scenario, which person would jump higher if one could squat 400 pounds and the other could squat 500 pounds? That answer is much harder to predict. If the person who squats 400 has a long history of sprinting and jumping, competing in sports, and is coordinated it is totally possible that he jumps significantly higher than the person who can squat 500 pounds. The lesson here is that it is important to get stronger, but don't let a pursuit of absolute strength take over as your main goal. Train for strength but realize that it is the third most important factor in jumping higher and it shouldn't detract from your other training.

There are studies that show that in training over a long period of time for absolute strength, you may negatively affect your rate of force development. The best way to train for strength is to lift no more than 60 to 80% (these are estimates and vary depending on the individual) of your maximal weight but to lift that weight as quickly and

as explosively as possible. I recommend frequent breaks from strength training and to remember that you are not training to be a powerlifter/bodybuilder, but to be an athlete. Adding too much muscle to your frame and becoming too bulky will weigh you down and not make you any more athletic. It can also decrease your mobility and structural integrity.

Chapter 6: Keys for Continued Success

The journey to having an elite vertical leap is a long one. There are many factors that go in to your athletic development and your potential for jumping high--some of which are in your control of and some of which you aren't. To achieve your goal, it is necessary to maximize each of the elements you control. After a ten-year journey that has led me to my highest jump of 47 inches, I have learned many of the keys to success the hard way. I struggled with years of injuries, years of little-to-no improvement and other issues. My hope is that through this chapter you expedite your process and avoid the mistakes I made, injuries I suffered, and plateaus I experienced.

The most important bit of advice I can give you is health-related. Your priority should be to maintain a healthy and finely functioning body. Do not train if you are in pain or injured. You will further damage yourself and limit future improvement by ruining your ability to train. Listen to your body and train intelligently. There are many ways to train and improve even during periods of injury. If you are dealing with knee pain there are still great ways to improve and work around it. For example, if you are dealing with shin splints, it could be a fantastic opportunity for you to add some pounds to your squat and deadlift while your shins recover.

Another important key is mobility and flexibility. When I first began training as a kid I was able to dunk every day for hours on a low rim without any consequences. In high school however that caught up to me as I dealt with severe quadriceps and patellar tendonitis. I was unaware as to what was causing my issues and the result was that I

lost a year and a half of training. I later learned techniques to avoid injury. Techniques like expanding my mobility, improving my squat patterns, correcting issues such as “knee valgus” (the inwards bowing of my knees), becoming more flexible, strengthening my quadriceps, and increasing my glute activation during jumps. I was able to alleviate most of my knee pain and I returned to dunking and working out nearly on a daily basis.

I highly recommend recommend stretching for 15 minutes every morning and night. Stretch every muscle group and foam roll your muscles as well. Again, as I have stressed over and over again, if you want to get better at jumping you need to jump more. It may sound basic, redundant, too simple even, but it is the only sure-fire way to see improvement. The problem with this is that jumping this much takes a huge toll on your body and in order to maintain it, stretching, foam rolling, mobilizing, icing, strengthening of certain functions and muscles, etc. is required.

Another *major* key is learning the value of core and hip strength. Every great athlete has a powerful core, and it is imperative that you develop one as well. The great thing about core workouts is that you can essentially do them daily. Exercises such as sit ups, planks, leg raises, v-sits, etc. are all crucial for becoming more athletic. Two of the best ones I can suggest are hanging leg raises and planks. Leg raises are excellent for developing strong abs and also powerful hips! Having strong hips will absolutely help you run faster and jump higher. Planks are great as well because they help you develop balance and anti-rotational core strength which is critical during the takeoff of your jump.

There is a helpful analogy regarding core strength that I will try to explain.

Imagine two pencils. One pencil is normal, and the other was snapped in two, then taped back together with scotch tape. If you were to bounce each pencil on a table, off of their eraser, which would bounce higher? The answer is the one that was not snapped in two. It has a rigid center which allows for the force to travel through it and propel it upwards. The one that was snapped and taped together would “bleed” energy through its center and not bounce as high. The same science applies to our bodies and our core. The stronger our core is, the more effectively force can travel through our bodies and propel us upwards.

The last key I would like to offer is to think critically. The best jumpers in the world got to where they are mainly by jumping hundreds and thousands of times. Do not be fooled by the latest trends and fashions. There is always some gimmick in the market promising to add a certain amount of interest to your vertical through some suspicious exercise program. No one can predict specific results for a certain individual, but with the right program anyone can improve. Become a student of the craft. Apply yourself and learn as much as you can about the science of jumping and structure your own program accordingly.

Chapter 7: How to Create Your Own Jump Program

A jump program should be aimed at getting you to jump higher through three different means. It should -

- 1) Have you jumping MORE
- 2) Have you perform frequent sprinting and plyometric exercises
- 3) Have you in the gym lifting 1-2 times a week

With all this information it is your duty to pick a credible vertical jump program or to create your own specific jump program tailored to your specific needs and strengths and weaknesses. There is no one-size-fits-all program and I cannot suggest a blanket program for all. However, there are some basics every program must cover.

My own program right now may be very different than the one that would best suit a beginner. For example, for the last year I've been dunking nearly every day, so my reactive strength and my jump technique are incredibly high (I would NEVER recommend that much volume of training to a beginner or intermediate level athlete), but I have made little strength increases this year and I am lacking in the speed department. So my program, if I were to write one right now, would be aimed to address my weaknesses (rate of force development and strength). I would lift (deadlifts and squats) twice a week, do sprints and plyometrics on a track once a week, and dunk once or twice a week. If you are lacking strength, I would recommend more lifting in that

program. For someone lacking more in the rate of force development I would recommend more sprinting, and for someone lacking enough jumping experience I would recommend more dunking/lower rim dunking practice.

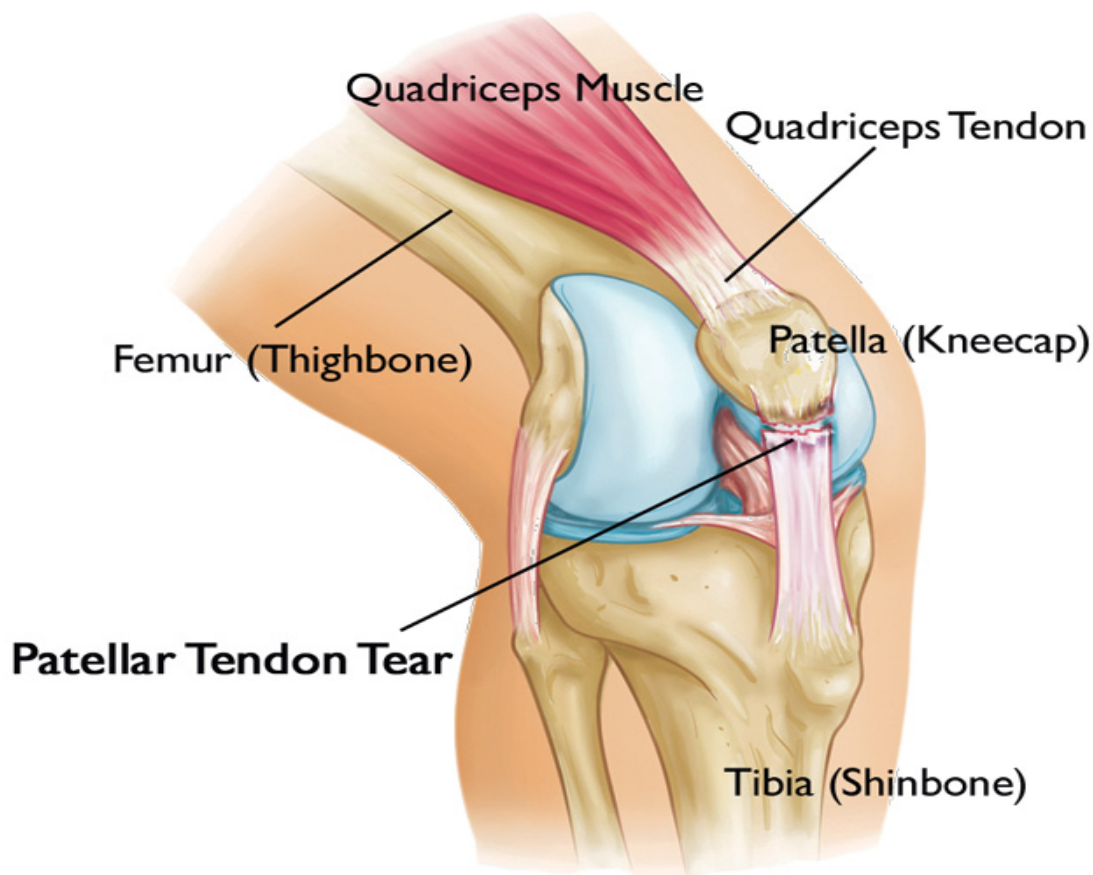
Creating your own jump program requires a high degree of self awareness and honesty. Measure your running vertical, if you jump less than 28 inches I would classify you as a beginner. If your running vertical is between 28 and 38 inches you would be intermediate, and anything higher I would classify as advanced. The closer to beginner you are, the more rapidly you can progress and the less volume of training you likely require.

Chapter 8: “Jumper’s Knee”



Before I give anyone advice on this topic, I should again remind you that I am not a physician and you should consult your doctor about any issues with your body.

Anyone who has played enough basketball or has ever trained to jump higher, has likely run into the dreaded “Jumper’s Knee”. Jumper’s knee has affected millions of athletes and still there isn’t much consensus on how to alleviate it. Jumper’s Knee is really Patellar Tendonitis, which is the inflammation of the patellar tendon. The image above points to where the patellar tendon is located in the knee. People often experience pain in the tendon above the knee and categorize it also as Jumper’s Knee, but it is probably Quadriceps Tendonitis.



Both forms of tendonitis can ruin your training career and if not treated properly can be very stressful to deal with. When suffering from knee pain, it is always a good idea to first consult your physician. If you are only dealing with manageable tendonitis then usually you can deal with it on your own. First locate it, investigate whether it is Quadriceps Tendonitis (above the knee) or Patellar Tendonitis (below the knee). Treatment for both is similar, but they have their subtle differences.

Typically, jumper's tendonitis will tend to be classic Jumper's Knee (Patellar Tendonitis). Firstly, Rest! Rest is the most important method of recovery, but rest alone is not enough. With just rest, your tendons will weaken dramatically and you won't be

addressing many of the reasons leading to why the tendonitis occurred. The most typical reason tendonitis occurs is “over-use”, so clearly resting more is beneficial. What is defined as over-use though? I dunk and train nearly everyday and I have been tendonitis free for quite some time, so what gives? Over-use injuries tend to take place because of faulty movement patterns, bad technique, lack of flexibility, immobility, and muscular weakness.

Firstly, the greatest way of dealing with Jumper’s Knee is by preventing it! Learn proper squat mechanics (be able to sit in a deep bodyweight squat with your chest up, heels on the floor, knees pushing slightly outwards). Look at the picture below for what a picture perfect squat looks like.



Odds are you, like myself, have been told to NEVER have your knees pass your toes during a squat but honestly that is faulty advice. Deep squats with more forward

knee bend can actually do wonders for your knees by strengthening your VMO and Rectus Femoris. The best thing I ever did for my knees was controlled squats with plenty of forward knee travel. Strong quads are critical in preventing knee pain.

Stretch everyday! It may feel monotonous, but it is an investment in your health and athletic career. Learn to foam roll, find areas you are particularly tight in (Lower back and IT band maybe) and massage them daily. Ensure you are warming up slowly and incorporating dynamic stretching before every workout. End workouts early if you are in pain and learn to listen to your body!

If you are already suffering from Jumper's Knee, all the advice above still applies! The difference is that you should take a small break from competing in your sport or training to address your movement patterns, mobility, flexibility and weaknesses. Once the pain settles down, begin strengthening your knees and tendons with training again. Warm up slowly and carefully, and limit your training. End your sessions before the pain returns and then begin to stretch. Ice after these training sessions. After some time your knees will be able to tolerate normal training sessions again with your new and improved flexibility, mechanics, mobility and strength. You will be on your way to breaking personal records with fully healthy knees in no time.

Chapter 9: The 10 Golden Rules For Jumping Higher

- 1) Jump MORE.
- 2) Increase your strength to weight ratio.
- 3) Work on core strength every day.
- 4) Train with friends! Competition will bring out the best in you.
- 5) Stretch and foam roll daily
- 6) Visualize success. Keep a positive attitude and trust the process. You will go through down time, but don't let that derail you.
- 7) Set plenty small realistic goals and break them. They will add up to something big.
- 8) Keep a good diet and maintain a lean body.
- 9) Perform sprint workouts at least a few times a month.
- 10) Have fun. That's the whole point right?

Chapter 10: Sample Jump Program

- Stretch every night (at a minimum)
- Workout your core at least 2 days per week
- Aim to increase weights used and difficulty of dunks made each week

Monday : Squats 3x5

- : Box jumps 3x5**
- : Step ups 3x6 each leg**
- : Max standing vertical jumps 8x1**

Tuesday: Deadlift 3x5

- : Kettle Bell Swings 3x8**
- : 60 Meter Sprints 4x1**

Wednesday/Friday/Sunday: Rest

Thursday: Dunk (low rim if necessary) for 30 min to 1.5 Hours. Challenge yourself to hit new dunks with either leg and two foot jumps.

Saturday: Dunk for 1-2 hours. Give every jump maximal effort.

Chapter 11: Self-Fulfilling Prophecies

I saved this chapter for the end for a reason. You've likely been told that jumping is a God given gift and that you are either born to fly or born to be a mere prisoner of gravity. Most of the highest jumpers in the world would likely jump higher than me despite never having a strict training regimen in their lives. I have dunked with the best dunkers in the world, and unfortunately it is true to some extent.

There are many factors that are almost purely genetic that you have little to no influence over. Just to list a few these are: height, limb length, central nervous system excitability, fast twitch muscle fiber percentage, injury susceptibility, etc. Longer limbs (legs specifically) will give you greater mechanical advantage when jumping (meaning you will require less force to jump higher than someone with shorter legs). We are all born with some percent of our muscle fibers being "Fast Twitch"; some will have a higher percentage than others and will be naturally more explosive. While these are unfortunate truths, you mustn't let them limit you.

I have seen and befriended dunkers of every body type. There is more than one recipe for an impressive vertical leap. I have a friend who is 5'8" and weighs only 130 pounds, but jumps as high as I do! There are also dunkers who weigh over 240 pounds. I even met an elite dunker who was 5'5! Regardless of the genetic factors you inherited, there is a path of success ahead of you should you choose to pursue it.

Chapter 12: My Answers To The 4 Most Common Vertical Jump Questions

- 1) **What is the best workout to jump higher?** *This is the question I am asked the most frequently. There is NO secret workout or trick to jump higher. The answer is dependent on who you are as an athlete. The workout that addresses your biggest weakness will be your most beneficial exercise. If you have weak hamstrings and hips, you will likely benefit the most from some form of deadlifting. If you are strong but not very explosive, you will likely respond to sprinting and other plyometric workouts very well. If you are already a well rounded athlete but you don't jump very high, then you will likely benefit the most from hour long dunk sessions (on any size hoop as long as each jump is maximal effort).*

- 2) **How long will I have to train to be able to dunk?** *The answer is I don't know. No-one does. Your improvements will be dependent on you age, training history, dedication, nutrition, and some genetic factors. What I can tell you though, is that I have seen many beginners (jumping somewhere around 24 inches) add between 3-8 inches of vertical in their first year of serious training. I have even seen improvements of 12+ inches in a single year, but that is incredibly rare.*

- 3) **How frequently should I train?** *I believe "training" is a life long process and that you should be "training" every day. I try to do something every day that helps further my goals and athletic development. I have gone through experimental periods of*

heavy lifting 7 days a week and I have once dunked for an hour a day for 30+ straight days. What I have found is that your ideal training routine is completely dependent on your athletic profile and program structure. Typically, lifting 1-2 times a week and jump training/sprinting 1-2 times a week is ideal, but again that depends on a variety of factors. Perhaps if you are focused on increasing strength you can lift 3-4 times a week and conversely if you are trying to “peak” and squeeze the most out of your current strength levels you may be jumping 3-7 days a week and not lifting at all. The only concrete advice there is, in regard to this question, is that you should give your body adequate rest. Take time off from training fatigued muscle groups or aches. Even on your “rest” days though I suggest keeping active. Perhaps go longboarding, play beach volleyball, or do core workouts.

- 4) What is the best advice for someone who wants to learn to dunk?** *Practice dunking. Go on the highest hoop that you can currently dunk on and rep out as many dunks as possible. Go on a 7-foot or 8-foot hoop and try to make every dunk imaginable. There are several hundred different dunk variations that will each provide you a unique training stimulus and improve your dunk coordination. Slowly move on to higher and higher hoops as your vertical increases and dunk skills grow over time.*

